

SHIA CANON

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Abstract

Example

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The Prophet designated Ali as his successor at Ghadir Khumm. Leadership passes through the Ahl al-Bayt by divine appointment, not community consensus.

Example: Of whomever I am the mawla, Ali is his mawla (Hadith of Ghadir Khumm). This is THE claim that separates Shia from Sunni succession is divine appointment, not shura (consultation). The dispute is not personal preference but theological principle.

0.1 2. Infallibility of the Imams (Isma)

The Imams are divinely protected from error in matters of faith and law.

Example: Twelve Imams from Ali (d. 661) to Muhammad al-Mahdi (occultation 874). Each Imam is masum (sinless, infallible in religious guidance). This contrasts with Sunni caliphs, who are fallible administrators. The Imam IS the living proof of divine guidance.

0.2 3. Martyrdom of Husayn (Karbala)

The massacre at Karbala (680 CE) is the defining event Husayn's sacrifice against tyranny is the moral center of Shia identity.

Example: Ashura annual commemoration with mourning processions, passion plays (taziyeh), and lamentation. Karbala IS the event that defines Shia temporal consciousness.

0.3 4. Occultation of the Twelfth Imam (Ghayba)

The Twelfth Imam, Muhammad al-Mahdi, entered occultation in 874 CE. He will return as the

Mahdi to establish justice before the Day of Judgment.

Example: Minor occultation (874-941) maintained contact through four deputies (sufara). Major occultation (941-present) means no direct representative. The Hidden Imams absence creates the jurisprudential gap that the marjaiyya system fills scholars govern in the Imams absence.

1. Constraints

MUST: Cite Quran, hadith, or Imam's teaching for d

MUST: Distinguish Twelver from Ismaili from Zaydi

MUST NOT: Apply Sunni jurisprudential categories to Sh

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0.4 5. Marjaiyya (Source of Emulation)

In the Imams absence, the most learned mujtahid becomes the marja al-taqlid the source laypeople follow for religious rulings.

Example: Grand Ayatollahs (Sistani in Najaf, Khamenei in Qom) serve as living authorities. Each Shia Muslim chooses a marja and follows his fatawa. This is NOT a pope multiple marjas coexist. The system IS distributed religious authority within clerical hierarchy.

0.5 6. Taqiyya (Precautionary Dissimulation)

Concealing ones faith under persecution is religiously permitted. Survival preserves the community.

Example: Quran 16:106 Whoever disbelieves in Allah after belief, except one who is forced while his heart is at peace with faith Centuries of minority status under Sunni rule made taqiyya an operational survival mechanism. It is NOT deception but permitted self-preservation under duress.